The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: U.S. Central Command Public Affairs

Donald Trump vowed to continue blockading **Iran's** ports. The president said America would "see how long they hold out", adding to concerns that the Strait of Hormuz will not reopen soon. The price of Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, settled at around $112 a barrel on Friday after surging to $126 on Thursday. Earlier Iran threatened "long and painful strikes" against American bases in the Middle East should hostilities resume.

Pete Hegseth, America's secretary of war, told Congress that a ceasefire with Iran "pauses" a deadline set by the War Powers Resolution. It requires presidents to get congressional approval to continue wars within 60 days of their start. That period ends on Friday. Legal experts have disputed Mr Hegseth's reading of the law.

American stockmarkets closed at record highs. Investors are betting that gains from the artificial-intelligence boom will outweigh the effects of the war in Iran. The S&P 500 rose by 10% in April, its biggest monthly jump since 2020. Earlier the Commerce Department announced that America's economy grew at an annualised rate of 2% in the first quarter of 2026, slightly below the expectations of economists.

Apple reported its best-ever earnings for the first quarter of the year, with revenue of $111bn, 17% higher than a year ago. iPhone sales were strong, and revenue from services such as cloud storage beat analysts' expectations. The company is on a roll with devices, but is a laggard in the AI race. In September **Tim Cook**, its boss for 15 years, will be replaced by John Ternus, who oversees hardware.

Israeli strikes killed at least four Palestinians in Gaza, according to local health officials. Hamas officials met mediators in Cairo to try to restart a ceasefire that has broken down in recent weeks. Meanwhile, Israel's navy intercepted an aid flotilla in international waters near Greece, preventing the boats from reaching Gaza and detaining activists.

Brazil's Congress pushed through a bill to shorten the prison sentence of **Jair Bolsonaro**, a hard-right former president, overriding President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's veto. Last year Mr Bolsonaro was sentenced to 27 years in jail for plotting a coup after his electoral defeat in 2022; the law reduces that to around two years. The Senate also recently rejected Lula's Supreme Court nominee.

America will remove **tariffs** on **Scotch whisky**. Export volumes to America, the largest market for Scotch by value, fell by 15% last year after the Trump administration imposed a levy of 10%. Mr Trump says the decision was in honour of King Charles, who carried out a state visit this week. The Scottish National Party, on the other hand, claimed it deserved the credit.

Figure of the day: 14m, the daily number of barrels of oil trapped by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Read the full story.

Photograph: Alamy

Nasdaq’s fast track

Large firms can now join America’s leading index for tech stocks at lightning speed. From Friday Nasdaq will let companies join its NASDAQ 100 index within 15 trading days of their initial public offerings if their market capitalisation puts them in the index’s top 40. Previously, they had to wait at least three months.

Nasdaq wants to take advantage of an expected series of mega-IPOs. SpaceX, a rocket firm owned by Elon Musk, might list at a valuation as high as $2trn—which would make its IPO the largest ever.

Joining the NASDAQ 100 would benefit SpaceX, too. The company’s shares would then be bought automatically by funds that track stockmarket indices, thereby lowering its cost of capital. But speedy entry, and other changes—including a reduction in the percentage of shares that index members must make publicly available—have raised worries that Nasdaq is too eager to pander to Mr Musk and his fellow tech moguls.

Photograph: Getty Images

A deadline for Donald Trump’s war

Donald Trump has a knack for missing his own deadlines. His war in Iran is no exception. The president initially estimated that the conflict would last “four to five weeks”. It has now dragged on for two months. On Friday he may miss another, more consequential, deadline: under the War Powers Resolution, a president can only wage war without congressional approval for 60 days. Republicans in Congress have so far blocked Democratic efforts to end Operation Epic Fury. But some have signalled they would not support an extension.

Mr Trump is likely to look for workarounds. The law allows a one-off, 30-day window to withdraw forces from hostilities, providing offensive operations end. On Thursday Pete Hegseth, the secretary of war, argued that America’s fragile ceasefire with Iran had “paused” the 60-day deadline for requiring congressional approval to continue wars. The president may also ignore that law altogether. In Washington these days, the only clock that matters is Mr Trump’s.

Photograph: Getty Images

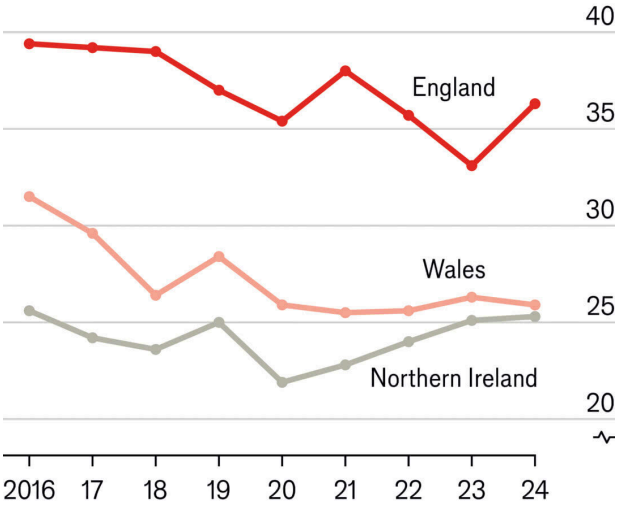
Britain is trying to clean up its rental market

Friday brings sweeping legislative reform to privately rented homes in England, which account for nearly 5m of the country's 25m dwellings. The Renters' Rights Act abolishes fixed-term tenancies (typically 12 months long), replacing them with contracts that roll over indefinitely. No-fault evictions, in which landlords can oust tenants without explanation, are now banned, too. Landlords will need to provide a valid reason, such as selling the property or unpaid rent.

Proponents say the changes give tenants much-needed security. But they may constrain supply by making it harder to raise rents. Landlords will not be able to let their properties for higher than the advertised price—ending bidding wars that have helped push up rents in recent years. Existing tenants will be able to challenge annual rent reviews at a tribunal. Many tenants believe landlords have been fleecing them. But according to one measure of affordability by Britain's Office for National Statistics, rent is cheaper now as a proportion of tenants' income than it was in 2016.

Bring down the house

Britain, private renters, average rent as % of median household income



Source: ONS

Photograph: Getty Images

America’s oil majors are down but not out

ExxonMobil and Chevron, two American oil giants, publish quarterly reports on Friday. Despite soaring prices for their main product (Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, briefly surpassed $125 a barrel on Thursday), the results will be painful. Preliminary guidance indicates that both companies expect a blow from the conflict in the Gulf. FactSet, a research firm, reckons the impact of the conflict will drag down profits for the broader S&P 500 energy sector by over 14% year on year. The closure of the Strait of Hormuz has reduced Exxon’s production in the Middle East by about 6%.

But there are two bright spots. First, the setback probably looks worse than it is—accounting rules mean that the short-term losses show up on the books before the extra profits from high oil prices do. Second, both firms have made big bets in America’s Permian shale basin and Guyana’s offshore patch, both reliable wells of earnings when faraway fields turn turbulent.

Photograph: AP

Stumbling on the runway: “The Devil Wears Prada 2”

All right everyone, gird your loins: “The Devil Wears Prada” is back. Twenty years ago Andy (Anne Hathaway) left *Runway*, the world’s most prestigious fashion magazine, and Miranda Priestly (Meryl Streep), its tyrannical editor-in-chief. Now a respected investigative journalist, she is brought back to shore up the magazine’s reporting after *Runway* goes viral for the wrong reasons.

The first film delighted viewers, in part, by inverting expectations: prepped to loathe the vapid, materialistic world of high fashion, they were presented with a spirited defence of it. “The Devil Wears Prada 2” is concerned about the present and future of journalism, but is less convincing in the case it tries to make for it. It argues that magazines like *Runway* are essential—“the last piece of wood floating next to the Titanic”, as Miranda puts it—yet concedes they have lost most of their cultural clout. So when the cast struts triumphantly in their couture, it feels all trousers, no talk.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which female tennis player took part in the Battle of the Sexes match against Bobby Riggs in 1973?

Thursday: Which buildings in Malaysia were the world's tallest from 1998 to 2004?

Some men are born mediocre, some men achieve mediocrity, and some men have mediocrity thrust upon them.

Joseph Heller